

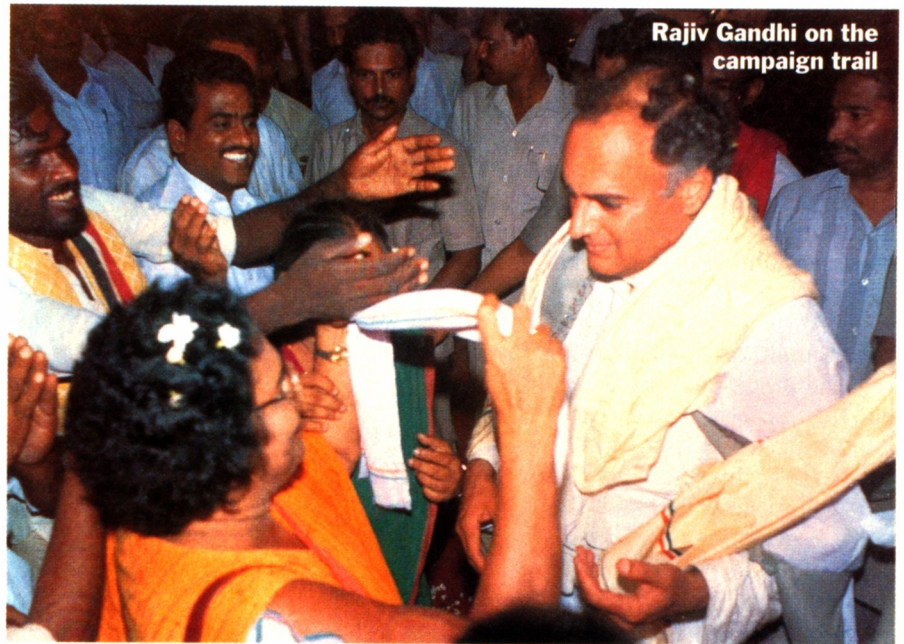
RAJIV GANDHI'S ASSASSINATION

The only human intelligence report of some relevance came from the German intelligence a few months before the assassination (on May 21, 1991) stating that a Sri Lankan Tamil living in Germany had been visiting Chennai and that he was reputed to be an expert in explosives. Unfortunately, this was not properly investigated by the IB. The entire focus of the intelligence coverage of the LTTE was on its activities in Sri Lanka, its gun running, etc. There was no specific focus on the likely threats to Rajiv Gandhi's security from it.

After the assassination, the monitoring division of the R&AW energised by (the head of the Sri Lanka division) S.A. Subbaiah, did outstanding work in tracking down the movements of those involved in the conspiracy to kill Rajiv Gandhi on an hour-to-hour basis, but the monitoring division too had failed to detect the conspiracy to kill Rajiv Gandhi before the tragedy took place. The interceptions made after the assassination and the repeated breaking of the LTTE's code by the code-breakers of the R&AW indicated that the LTTE's communications security was poor. If it was poor after the assassination, it was most likely that it was poor before it too. The monitoring before the assassination was not as systematic as it was after it.

ARMS TRAINING FOR THE RSS

In a potentially controversial move, Vinod Pandey (V.P. Singh's cabinet secretary in 1989) wanted the R&AW to organise clandestine arms training for the cadres of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) in the Jammu area so that they could be used for countering Pakistan-sponsored terrorists. One had the impression that this idea had originated from L.K. Advani, the BJP leader, who was exercising pressure on the government to start this training quickly. The R&AW felt very uncomfortable about this idea. Under sustained pressure from Pandey, it held two secret meetings with a representative of the Jammu branch of the RSS to



Rajiv Gandhi on the campaign trail

R&AW held two secret meetings with a representative of the RSS to discuss the modalities of training.

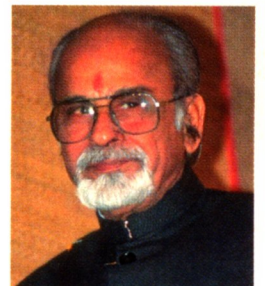
discuss the modalities of the training. The first meeting was held in a Jammu hotel and the second in hotel Ambassador in Delhi. By then, serious differences had cropped up between V.P. Singh and the BJP over Advani's plan to take a rath yatra to Ayodhya to seek public support to its demand for the construction of a Ram temple in the place then occupied by the Babri Masjid. Pandey directed the R&AW not to take further action on the project which remained a non-starter.

LTTE'S PAKISTAN CONNECTION

Through the interception of the LTTE's communications—(R&AW detected) an attempt by the LTTE to smuggle a consignment of arms and ammunition from Karachi... given to the LTTE by Pakistan's Harkat-ul-Mujahideen with the complicity of the ISI. The movement of the LTTE ship (*MV Ahat*)...was ultimately intercepted... (but) its crew set fire to it as a result of which it sank... Kittu, a close confidant of Prabhakaran, who was travelling on the ship, chose to commit suicide....

GUJRAL SHUTS THE COVERT DIVISION

At the same time, Rajiv Gandhi was convinced—as strongly as his mother was—that India's preoccupation had to be not with



RED SIGNAL: Gujral

individual Pakistani leaders, who are a passing phenomena, but with the Pakistani mindset, which was an enduring phenomenon right from the day Pakistan was born in 1947. In India, there is no such thing as an enduring mindset towards Pakistan. The mindsets keep changing with leaders and circumstances. It is not so in Pakistan. The compulsive urge to keep India weak, bleeding and destabilised influences policy-making in Pakistan—whatever be the leader, civilian or military. It has nothing to do with its humiliation in Bangladesh in 1971. It was there before 1971 and has been there since 1971. Some leaders such as those of the fundamentalist parties openly exhibit it, but others manage to conceal it behind seeming warmth in their behaviour. Till that mindset changes, India has to adopt a mix of incentives and disincentives in its operational policies towards Pakistan—